

Padmanabhan. Although many have blamed the reduction in ridership on the growing incidence of ticketless travel, over-the-counter ticket sales on Mumbai's suburban rail network contribute significantly to the railways' earnings. Hence, the move may also be an attempt to discourage passengers from shifting to road transport.

Introduced in 2019 as Train 18, the indigenously designed Vande Bharat has proved a big success, with 19 services currently operational. "Given the move to rapid rail transit, inspired by the Delhi-based National Capital Region Transport Corp., Indian Railways is replicating a success story. Rail-based transit is always better than car-based transit, especially for a North-South city like Mumbai," states Shailesh Pathak, an urban transport expert and Secretary General at the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce & Industry.

Pathak also feels that commercial and safety aspects may have played a vital role in the choice of Vande Bharat rakes. "Hence, the economic rate of return is more important than purely financial internal rate of return parameters. Further, with passenger coach doors closed while in motion, loss of life would be completely obviated." In 2022, 700 people lost their lives after falling off running trains, according to Government Railway Police (GRP) data. Pathak too feels that with the introduction of the new rakes, the suburban rail network and metro rail will complement each other.

It was in 1925, that a four-car EMU service was launched between Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Terminus (then called Victoria Terminus) and Kurla. A first for India, that event marked the dawn of modern, rail-based urban transportation here. With the introduction of the Vande Bharat local, the railways will leapfrog to the next level. **BT**

@manishpant22

| START-UPS |

Chasing CFOs

Several start-ups have appointed CFOs in the past few months. What's driving this sudden shift in their strategy?

BY BHAVYA KAUSHAL

▶ **A GURUGRAM-BASED** start-up recently found out just how much things have changed with the onset of the funding winter. The firm is looking to raise funds, but it was stumped by a request from potential investors: Hire a chief financial officer (CFO).

"We are looking for a CFO who has previous experience in fundraising," the founder tells *Business Today* on the condition of anonymity.

Another start-up, this one based in Chandigarh, has been on the hunt for a CFO for three

months. The start-up has launched a frantic search for CFOs, and not just the small ones. In January, fintech major BharatPe hired former SBI Card CFO Nalin Negi. Surprisingly, the fintech unicorn had functioned without an officially-appointed CFO since its inception in 2018. It had appointed professional services firm Alvarez & Marsal as the interim CFO after Co-founder Ashneer Grover's ouster.

BYJU'S, the world's most valuable edtech company, appointed a CFO in February after running into a series of

NOT FOCUSING ON JUDICIOUS DEPLOYMENT OF FUNDS IS ONE FATAL TRAP THAT FOUNDERS ARE NOW TRYING TO AVOID

months, but for a different reason. "With the funding winter setting in, we want to keep track of our finances. Earlier, we were able to manage with a part-time CFO. But now, keeping track of every penny is important," says the founder of the company.

SEARCH PARTY

Over the past few months, st-

controversies. Ajay Goel, a finance veteran with previous experience in companies like Vedanta, was entrusted the job. Apart from these, other names like Dealshare, Zepto, and Coinswitch have also appointed CFOs over the past few months.

THE SHIFT

What is driving this sudden change? Experts believe the past